ART

PLAY TO THE GALLERY

Gallery Art Exposure's second outpost on Kolkata's Lake View Road looks to encourage the creation of a gallery ecosystem in the city

In 2018, art connoisseur Somak Mitra founded Gallery Art Exposure in Kolkata. Six years since, in 2024, the city sees the gallery's second outpost on Lake View Road, the doors opening to the public in the last week of September with the exhibition, *Miracle of Absence*.

"We needed a bigger space to do some cutting-edge exhibitions in Kolkata. We also wanted to run contemporary programmes in parallel, and this space is perfect for that as it's across two floors. We can have two parallel exhibitions at any given point," says Mitra about the 7,000 sq. ft gallery.

The new gallery, despite being housed in an old structure, has a quaint fluidity in its layout. The two floors also have distinct identities, with one being more expansive, while the other is designed by interlocking some interconnected sections. "We are working on interactive and engaging programming to make it more accessible and easy. We also intend to show both the modern and the contemporary, so the audience will be much larger," he says.

With the maiden show setting the tone for the future, Mitra aims to widen the reach of the city and represent more South Asian talent on home turf. "At the ongoing show, the participating artists are Abir Karmakar, Chittrovanu Mazumdar, Amitava, Shambhavi Singh, Mithu Sen, Ricky Vasan, Baaraan Ijlal, Ratheesh T., T. Venkanna, Buddhadev Mukherjee, Anandajit Ray and Gigi Scaria," says the gallerist, underlining the range of styles and mediums traversed by the artists on display.

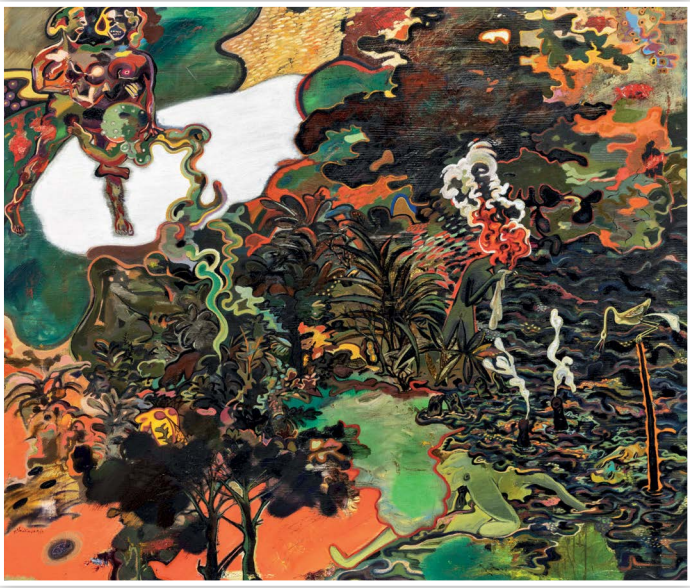
Curated by Gayatri Sinha, the exhibition draws its name from a line by poet Mirza Ghalib, which says,

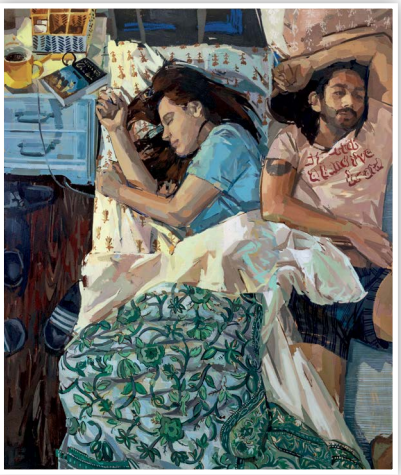
***Miracle of Absence* is on display at Gallery Art Exposure, Lake View Road, Lake Terrace, Kolkata, till Nov. 30**

"The miracle of your absence is that I found myself while searching for you." The 12 artists have responded to this idea of finding form and meaning in the absence with unique creative idioms—from giant paintings to sculptures—exploring the precarity of life, evoking desires, and finding humour in the wayward nature of human beings.

The gallery's calendar already looks full for the coming months. "We open Suruchi Choksi's solo show on December 7 as a Bengal Biennale collateral. We are also opening a Jogen Chowdhury Retrospective on February 16—which also happens to be his 87th birthday—across two floors with a body of over 150 works. Our calendar is planned for the next year with two major curated group shows, along with multiple solo exhibitions of the artists we represent," Mitra says, adding that he hopes to find more promising art and artists through his newest endeavour. ■

–Arshia





« **DIFFERENT SHADES** Clockwise from top, T. Venkanna's 'Sea of Desire'; 'Artwork' by Mithu Sen; Anandajit Ray's 'Equine'; Ricky Vasan's 'Sleep Well, Goodnight Love'



